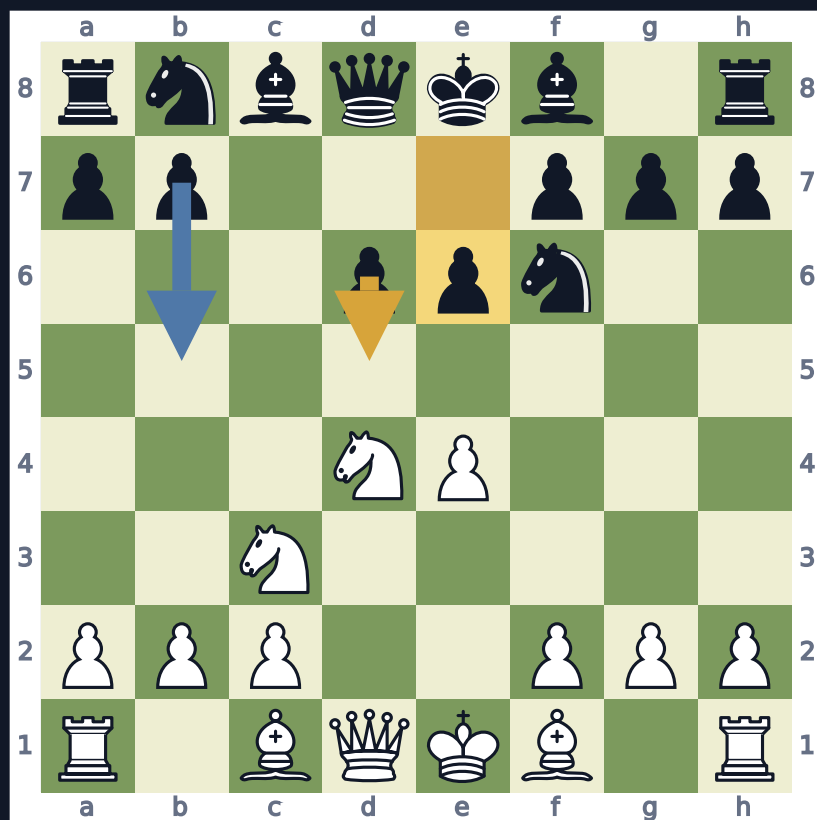


02

The Three Sicilian Centers

Open, Scheveningen, and ...e5 structures; how pawn placement assigns every piece a job.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will recognize the central skeleton first and know which break, weak square, and minor-piece trade belongs to it.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 007 | PAGE 4

Decode: Scheveningen small center

The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

LESSON 008 | PAGE 8

Play: Scheveningen small center

The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

LESSON 009 | PAGE 12

Decode: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

LESSON 010 | PAGE 16

Play: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

LESSON 011 | PAGE 20

Decode: The ...d5 liberation break

A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

LESSON 012 | PAGE 24

Play: The ...d5 liberation break

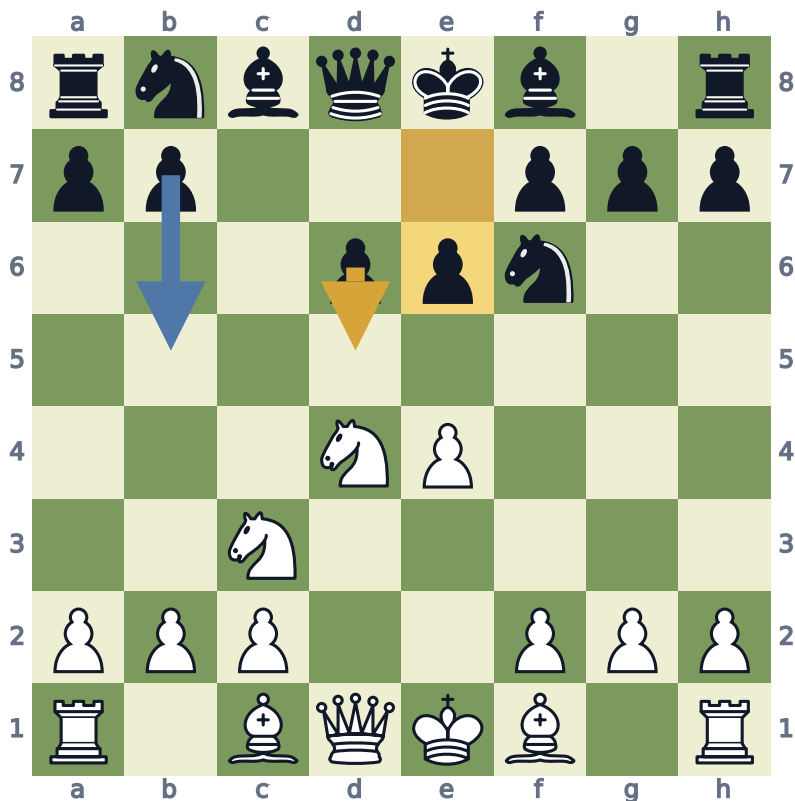
A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will recognize the central skeleton first and know which break, weak square, and minor-piece trade belongs to it.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Scheveningen small center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

DECISION RULE

Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces.

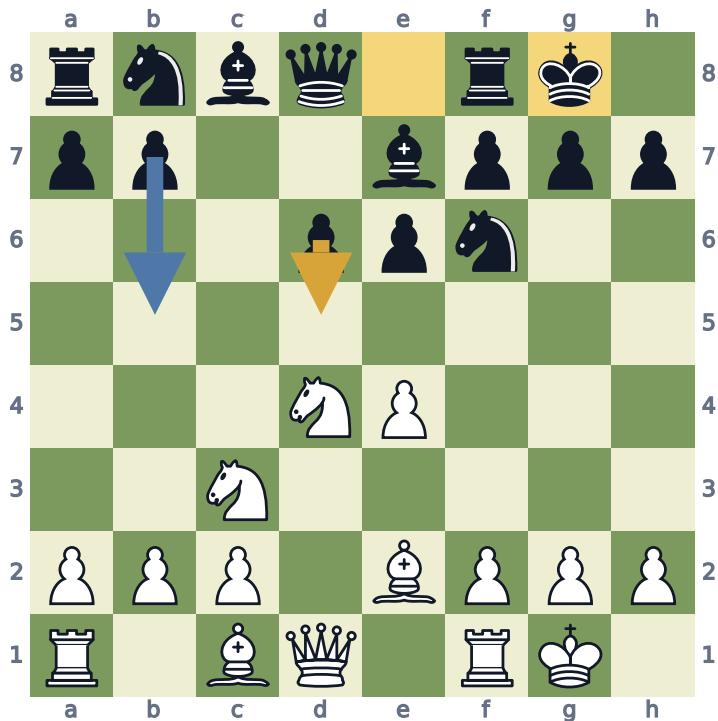
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break.

MEMORY RULE | The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break.

FAILURE MODE

Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

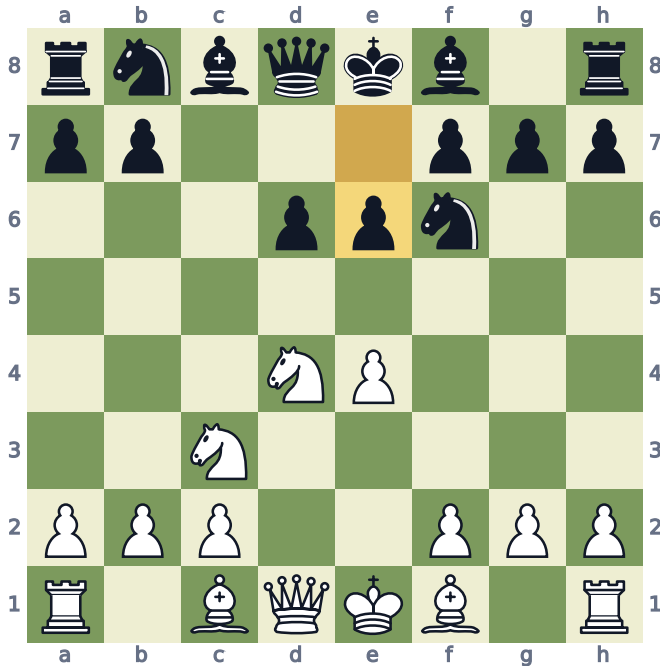
RULE | The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O



- d4: White builds the Open Sicilian center and offers the d-pawn for rapid development.
- cxd4: Black releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? White's resistance is: White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break. The line fails as a template when: Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

STORE THIS | The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

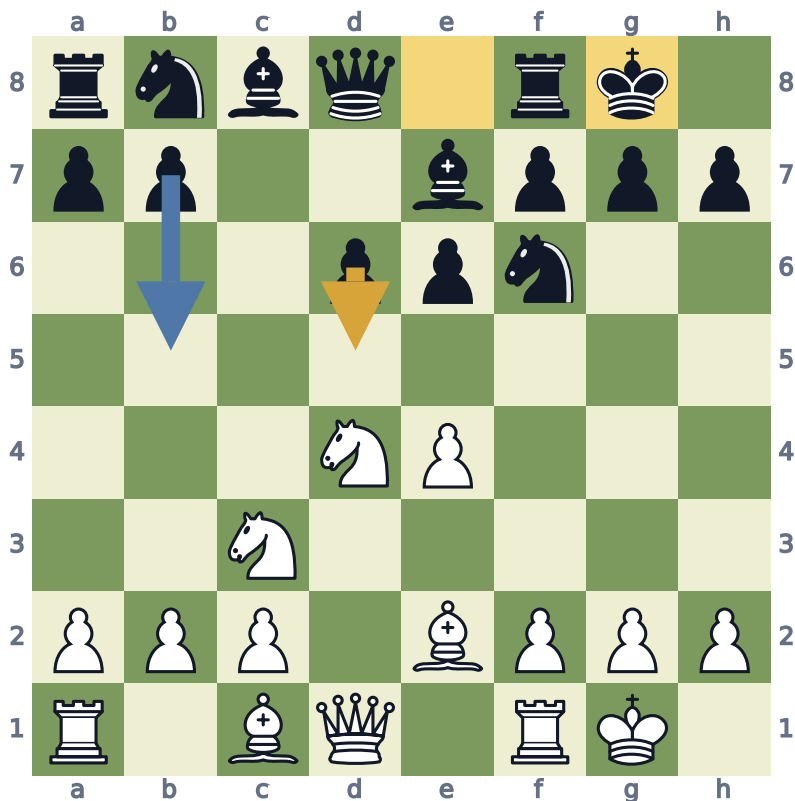
1. Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks. 2. Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces. 3. White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break. 4. Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? 5. Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Scheveningen small center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

DECISION RULE

Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces.

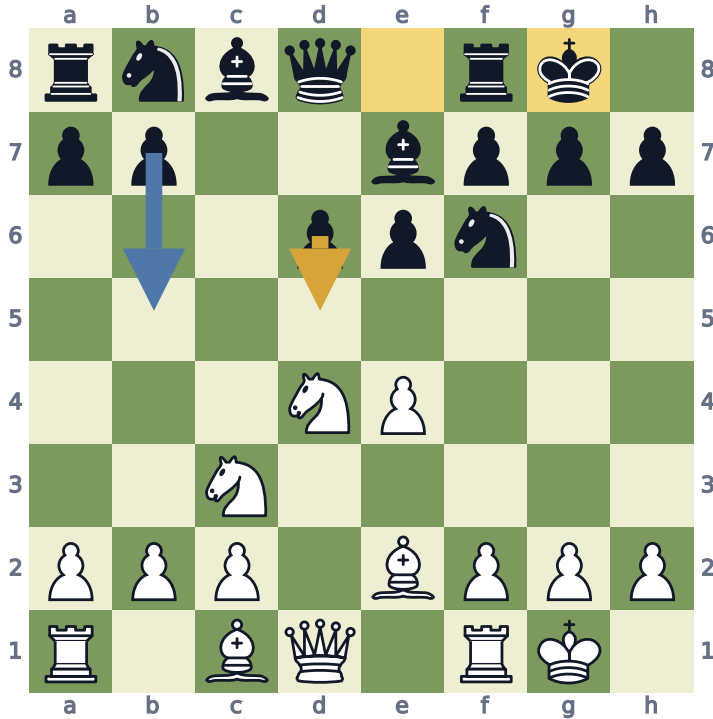
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break.

MEMORY RULE | The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break.

FAILURE MODE

Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

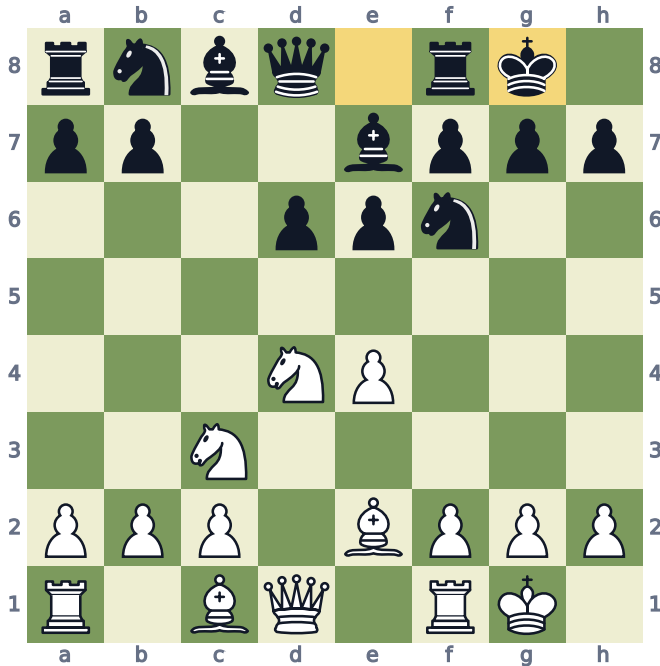
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O



- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? White's resistance is: White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break. The line fails as a template when: Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

STORE THIS | The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

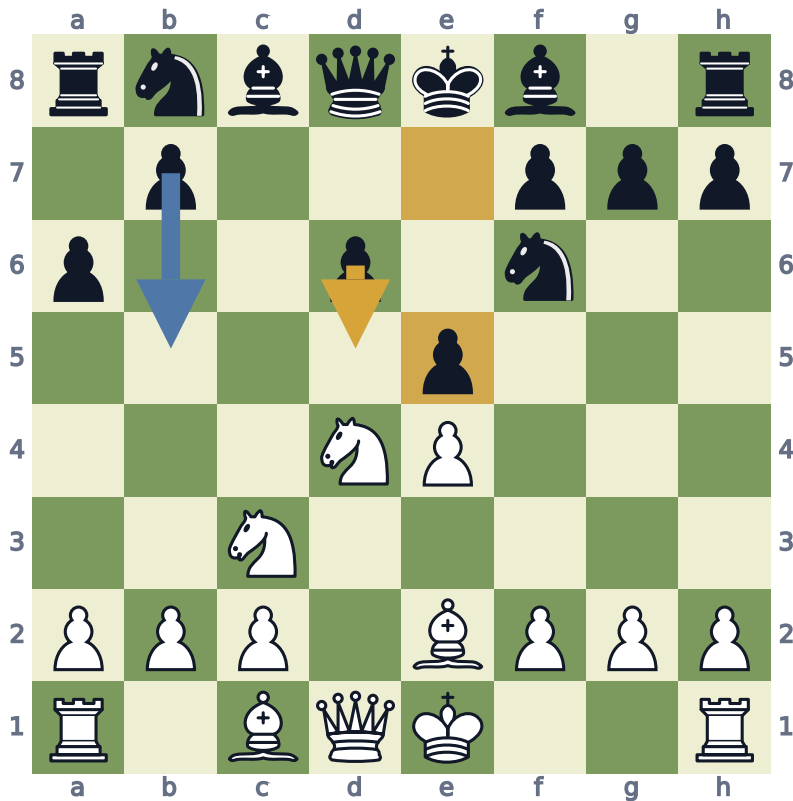
1. Pawns on d6 and e6 form a compact shell. Black concedes space temporarily in exchange for flexible ...d5 and ...b5 breaks. 2. Complete development, watch e5 and d5, and time ...d5 when exchanges release the cramped pieces. 3. White adds pressure with f4, Qf3, Be3, and sometimes g4 before Black equalizes with a break. 4. Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square? 5. Remaining passive because the shell looks safe; without a break the space deficit becomes permanent.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

DECISION RULE

What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible.

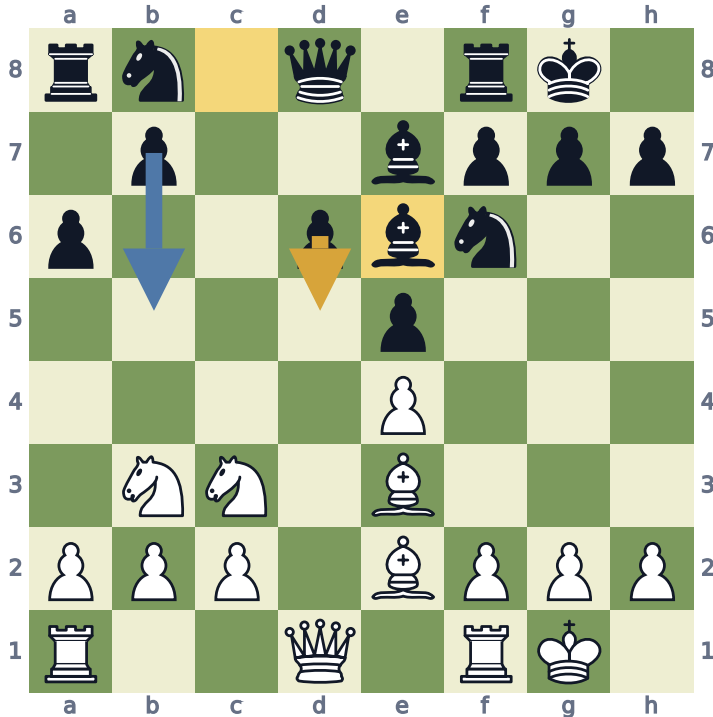
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure.

MEMORY RULE | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure.

FAILURE MODE

Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

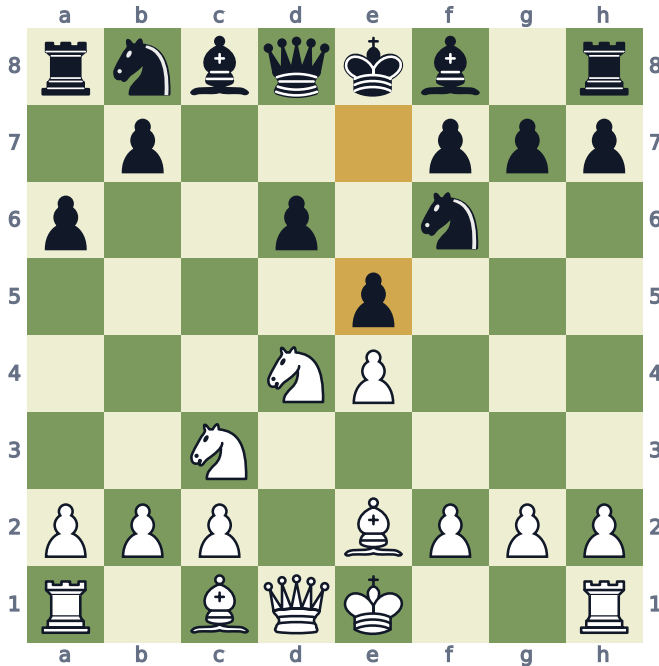
RULE | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? White's resistance is: White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure. The line fails as a template when: Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

STORE THIS | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

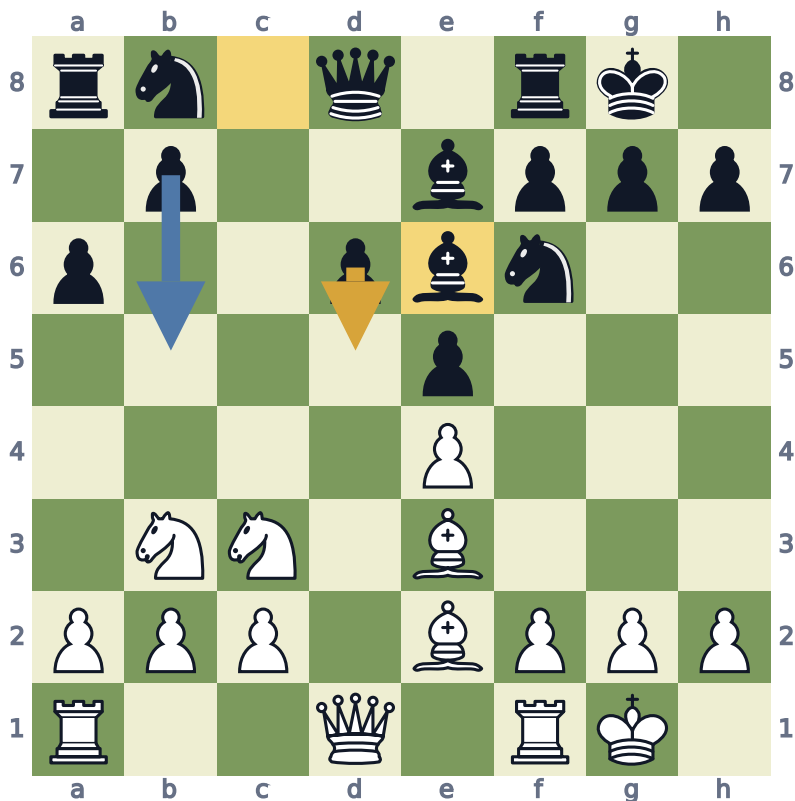
1. ...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward. 2. Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible. 3. White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure. 4. What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? 5. Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

DECISION RULE

What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible.

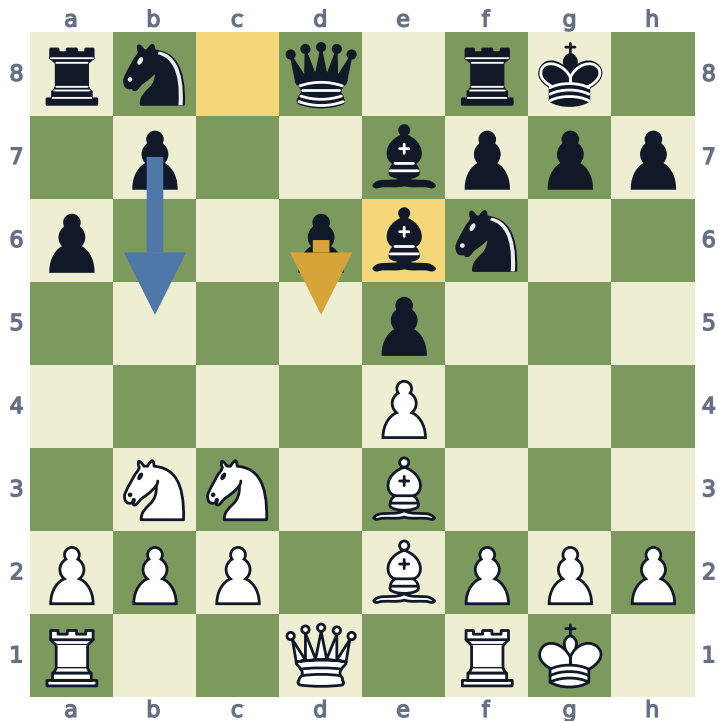
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure.

MEMORY RULE | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure.

FAILURE MODE

Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

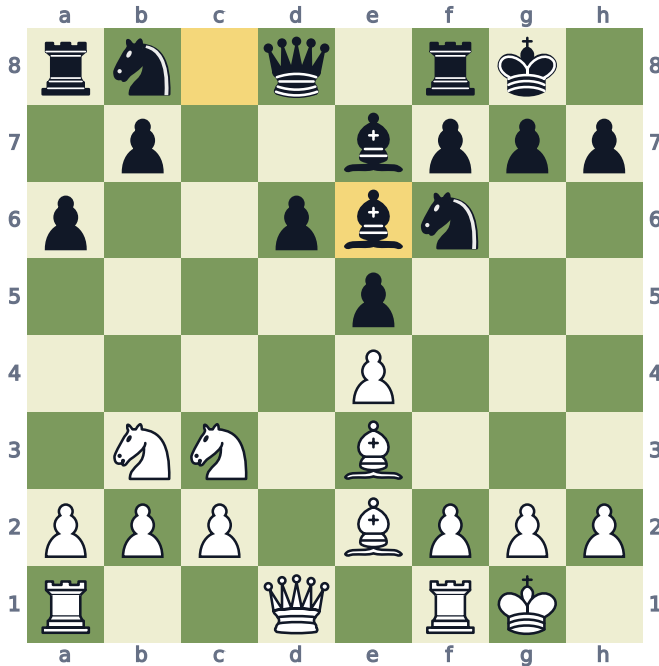
RULE | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6



- Nb3: White reroutes a knight to b3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? White's resistance is: White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure. The line fails as a template when: Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

STORE THIS | ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

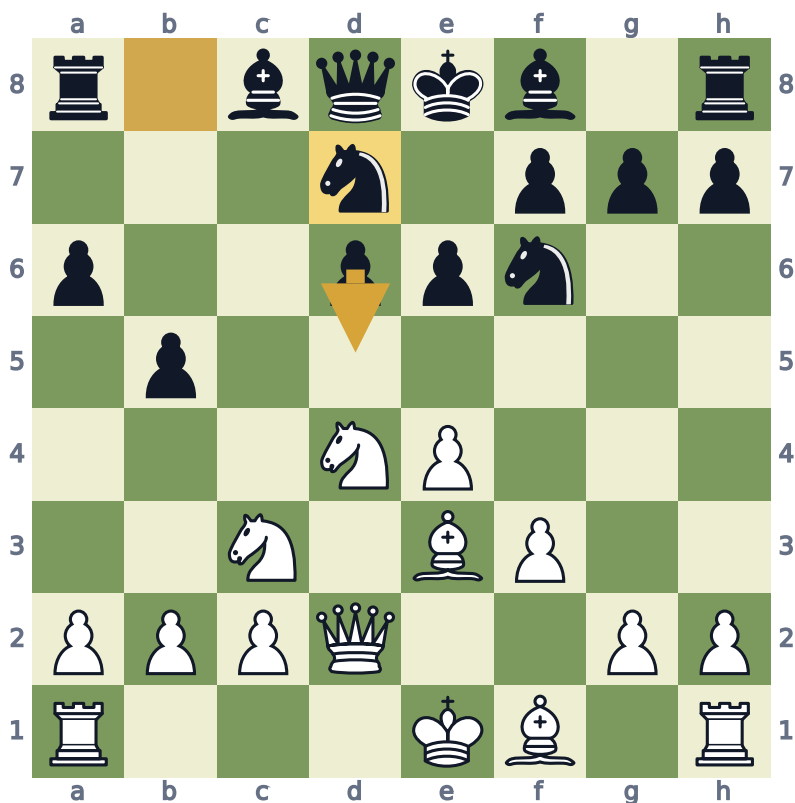
1. ...e5 gains time on the knight and controls d4, but it permanently weakens d5 and leaves d6 backward. 2. Control d5 with ...Be6, ...Nbd7, and rooks on central files; seek ...d5 only when preparation makes it possible. 3. White installs a knight on d5, trades the defender on f6, or attacks d6 after fixing Black's structure. 4. What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5? 5. Admiring the space gain while allowing Nd5 under favorable circumstances.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The ...d5 liberation break



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

DECISION RULE

After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces.

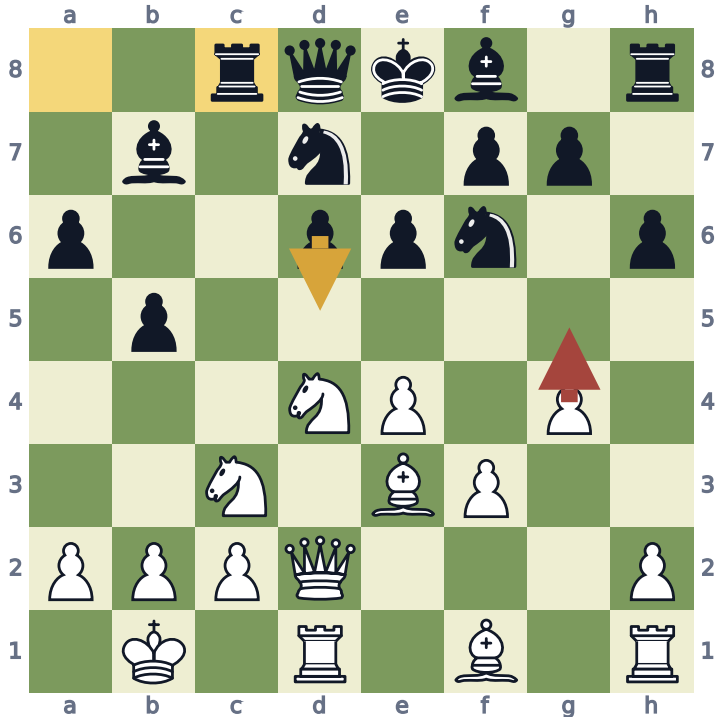
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside.

MEMORY RULE | A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

BLACK AIMS FOR

Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

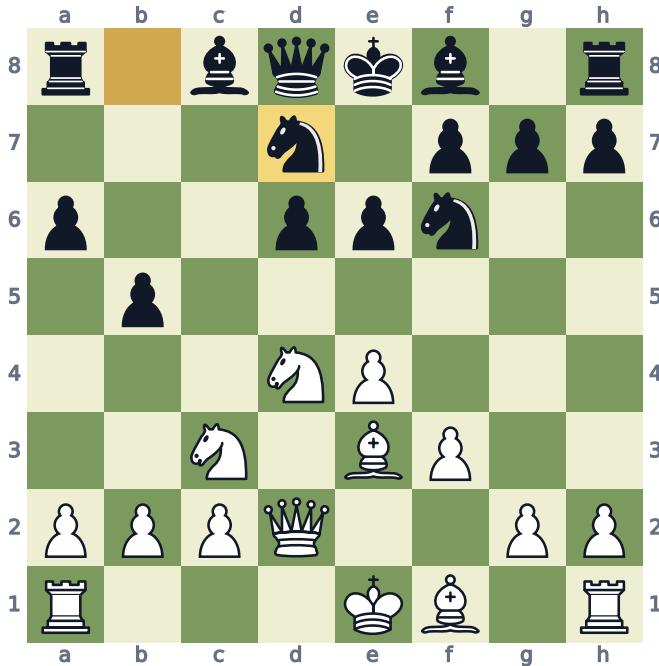
RULE | A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5 8. f3 Nbd7 9. g4 h6 10. O-O-O Bb7 11. Kb1 Rc8



- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- b5: Black starts queenside expansion and prepares files or a bishop diagonal.
- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? White's resistance is: White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

STORE THIS | A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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ANSWER KEY

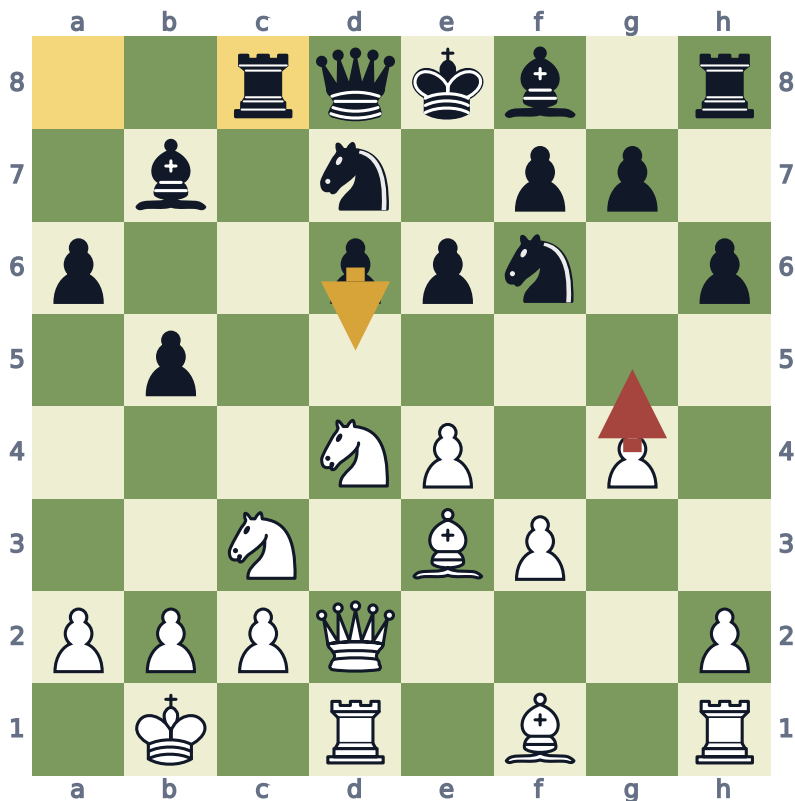
1. Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety? 2. Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces. 3. White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside. 4. After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? 5. Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5 8. f3 Nbd7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The ...d5 liberation break



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

DECISION RULE

After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces.

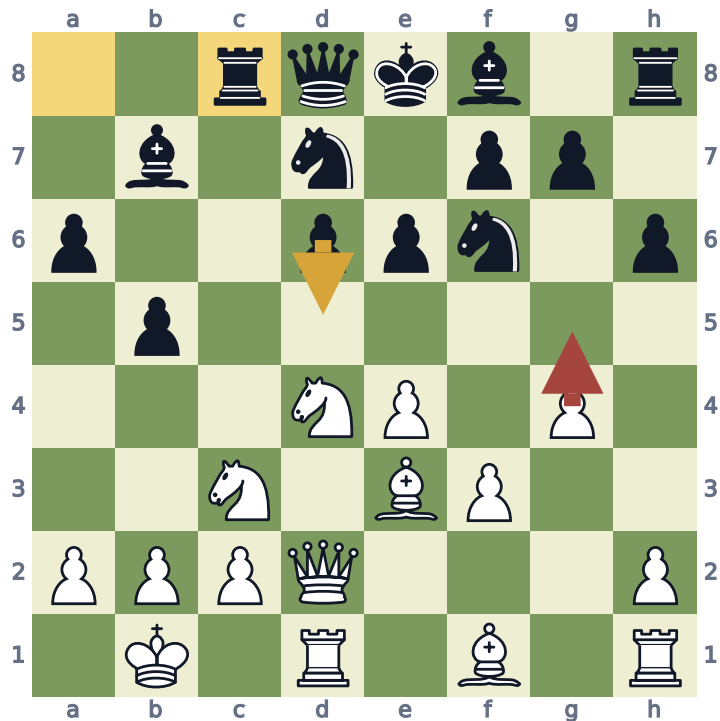
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

BLACK AIMS FOR

Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

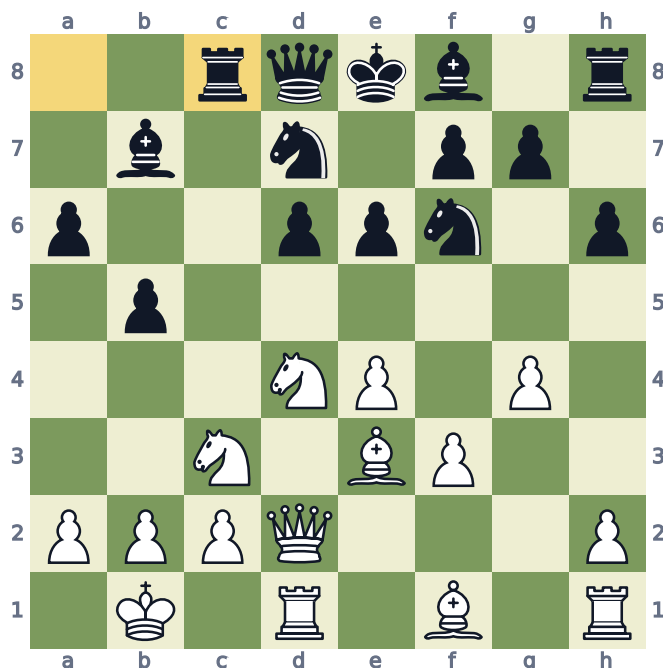
RULE | A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5 8. f3 Nbd7 9. g4 h6 10. O-O-O Bb7 11. Kb1 Rc8



- g4: White starts a direct pawn storm and threatens to gain time on the f6 knight.
- h6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- O-O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Kb1: White improves coordination and changes the candidate set.
- Rc8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety?

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? White's resistance is: White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

STORE THIS | A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Many Sicilians are strategically organized around one question: can Black achieve ...d5 without losing material or king safety? 2. Improve control of d5, distract White on the c-file or queenside, and break only when the resulting exchanges activate the pieces. 3. White restrains ...d5, keeps more space, and launches first on the kingside. 4. After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo? 5. Playing ...d5 because it is thematic without calculating every forcing capture.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. g4 h6 10. O-O-O Bb7 11. Kb1 Rc8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 007 Decode: Scheveningen small center

Prompt: Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square?

Recall: The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

LESSON 008 Play: Scheveningen small center

Prompt: Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square?

Recall: The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

LESSON 009 Decode: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

Prompt: What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5?

Recall: ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

LESSON 010 Play: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

Prompt: What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5?

Recall: ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

LESSON 011 Decode: The ...d5 liberation break

Prompt: After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo?

Recall: A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

LESSON 012 Play: The ...d5 liberation break

Prompt: After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo?

Recall: A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Scheveningen small center

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O

Decision: Does ...d5 work tactically now, or does one white piece still overload the d5 square?

Memory: The small center is a spring: defend it, then release it with ...d5.

CARD 2

The Najdorf ...e5 clamp

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6

Decision: What is the concrete plan for the d5 hole before committing the e-pawn to e5?

Memory: ...e5 gains a tempo but creates a square; every gain sends a bill.

CARD 3

The ...d5 liberation break

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5 8. f3 Nbd7 9. g4 h6 10. O-O-O Bb7 11. Kb1 Rc8

Decision: After ...d5, can White capture, push, or exploit an opened diagonal with tempo?

Memory: A freeing break is earned by control, not by hope.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
007 Decode: Scheveningen small center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
008 Play: Scheveningen small center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
009 Decode: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
010 Play: The Najdorf ...e5 clamp	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
011 Decode: The ...d5 liberation break	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
012 Play: The ...d5 liberation break	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.